

Week 30: Questions

BIG IDEA

You do not need every answer to have gospel conversations; the art of asking good questions is the key tool. Two simple questions, 'What do you mean by that?' and 'How did you come to that conclusion?', dig deeper, buy time to think, and show genuine loving interest that builds relationship.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Going out to have spiritual conversations is terrifying for introverted students, and having a plan of attack helps.
- We feel we must answer every question to convince people, but nothing could be further from the truth; everyone gets stumped sometimes.
- The strategy this week is asking good, probing questions rather than yes-or-no ones, especially when you do not know the other person's view.
- First question: 'What do you mean by that?' It makes the person clarify their statement and buys you time to think more thoroughly.
- Second question: 'How did you come to that conclusion?' Asked with genuine interest, not attitude, it shows you actually want to know what they think.
- Asking great questions shows love and builds relationship, so when a person receives Christ, discipleship can actually begin rather than just a conversion.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. What makes starting a spiritual conversation feel terrifying, and how could a plan of attack help you?
2. Why is it a mistake to think you must have all the answers before sharing your faith?
3. Practice: someone says 'God can't exist because there's too much evil.' How would you use the two questions in reply?
4. How does asking good questions show love and build relationship instead of just feeding someone your opinion?

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LEADER VIDEO — FULL TRANSCRIPT

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Going out is terrifying

0:05 Last week we talked about the need for love when we're engaging in conversation. We want to get out there, and we want to be loving to other people. But if you or any of your students are like me, that very concept is terrifying. It's the fact that I have to go out — not the love part, that's not so terrifying, but the part where you go out and actually have a conversation. That part is terrifying. I need a plan of attack. I am very introverted and very reserved, and I'm sure some of your students are too. I'm not all that good at small talk, at just having a conversation. In fact, I actively try to avoid small talk. I like to get to the point.

When you can't answer

0:49 So when I'm entering a conversation about spiritual things, or when I want to advance a conversation and get to the gospel so that I can get to Jesus — because I want them to know who Jesus is — I need a plan of attack. But I'm sure that many of your students, and maybe you yourself, ask this, because I know I get there all the time: what happens when they ask you a question that you can't answer? Here is what happens in those moments. Somebody asks us a question.

1:16 We really want to have an answer, to come right back and say, "Yeah, I've got that answer, and I've got that answer," because we feel like if we have all of the answers, then we can somehow convince the other person that what we believe is absolutely right — we've got all the answers to all their questions. Well, nothing could be further from the truth. That's not at all the case. There are going to be times when we get stumped and we don't know what to say, or the person we're talking to has a belief system or a view on things that we're just not all that familiar with. You can't know everything about every single person.

The art of asking questions

1:48 But there's a really simple strategy that I want you to add in and to talk about with your students: when you're engaged in a conversation, you want to make sure that you are asking questions. That's what this week is all about — the idea and the art of asking questions. Questions are so, so important. If we ask good questions, then we're probably going to get good answers. Just like any good teacher knows, you don't ask yes-or-no questions. You ask in-depth, probing questions — "why" kinds of questions — to draw out of people the answers that you want, the answers that you need.

2:29 The same holds true in our conversations. This especially works if you have no idea what the other person is talking about, because you can probe a little bit deeper and get them to talk it through. At the same time, you're giving off the idea — because you are, and because you want to be — that you're extremely interested in what they have to say. That goes back to last week, when we talked about love and building relationships and that sort of thing. So there are two specific questions that we can ask somebody if you get stumped.

What do you mean by that?

- 3:01 The first question is simple: what do you mean by that? This question is used when you're really not sure what the person thinks, when the person says something that you're just not all that clear on. "I believe that Jesus is just a good moral teacher." What do you mean by that? You can probably guess what they might mean, but maybe that's not it at all. "God just doesn't exist, because there's too much evil in the world." Well, what do you mean by that? You can "what do you mean by that" people to death. You can go over and over and over again: what do you mean by that, or some variation of it.
- 3:50 It's a very simple question, but it does two things. First, it digs deeper into the person and what they're actually thinking. Second, it buys you time to think about what you want to say. It allows them to clarify what they're saying, so they can't just make a one-off statement to you, and it buys you a little bit of time to think through their opinion more thoroughly and more thoughtfully.

How did you come to that?

- 4:14 The second question is: how did you come to that conclusion? Again, people make one-off statements all the time. How did they get there? So if they said something like, "God can't exist because there's too much evil in the world" — well, how do you come to that conclusion? There's a much larger explanation that I need for that. And you don't say it with an attitude; you say it as someone who is genuinely interested. How did you come to that conclusion? Really? I really want to know. I'm really interested in what you have to say.
- 4:52 What this does is help them see that you are actually interested in what they have to say, that you actually want to know what they think rather than just giving them what you think. There's a big difference between the two. And again, that's why last week and this week are connected together, because by doing this kind of thing you're showing them love, you're showing them relationship, you're showing that you care about them as a person and not just feeding them your opinion.

The most valuable tool

- 5:20 The most valuable tool that you or your students have is the ability to sit down face-to-face with somebody and have a conversation. There are a lot of tips and tricks to share for that face-to-face time, but the number one thing to keep in your toolbox is the ability to ask great questions and to engage in deep, meaningful conversations with another person. It does so much more than just give the gospel. It builds relationship, so that when that person finally receives Christ, discipleship can actually begin, rather than just a conversion.